

MCP vs API

Admins ask which one to use and usually get a vague answer. Here's a straight one, with the scenarios to back it up.

01 · THE DIFFERENCE

Different strengths, built for different users

API

BUILT FOR CODE

A developer writes code that calls one exact endpoint, with exact parameters, in an exact format. It does the same thing every time.

```
GET /accounts/{id}/activity
?since=2026-09-01&type=meeting
```

MCP

BUILT FOR AI

The AI sees which tools are available, picks the one that fits the question, and fills in the details from what the person asked.

"Who have we been talking to at **Halden Freight** in the last 30 days, and when?"

EXAMPLES ARE ILLUSTRATIVE, NOT REAL BACKSTORY ENDPOINTS

THINK OF IT THIS WAY

- API** You fill out the form yourself, every field, every time.
- MCP** You say what you need. Someone who knows the forms picks the right one and fills it in.

NOT EITHER/OR

MCP doesn't replace the API. It can sit on top of an existing API and give AI a standard way to use it. Backstory's AI summaries come only through MCP. The API handles bulk export and pushing activity in.

Person → Claude → MCP → API → Backstory data

02 · WHICH ONE?

Ask who's on the other end, and whether the question changes

Use MCP when

- A person is in the loop
- The question changes each time
- The answer needs Backstory's AI summaries and judgment

Use the API when

- The same job runs on a schedule
- The output has to be exact, every time
- The result feeds another system, like a bulk export

The gray zone

Recurring reports a person still reviews. Move record and metric data to the API. Reports built on summaries stay with a person running them in MCP.

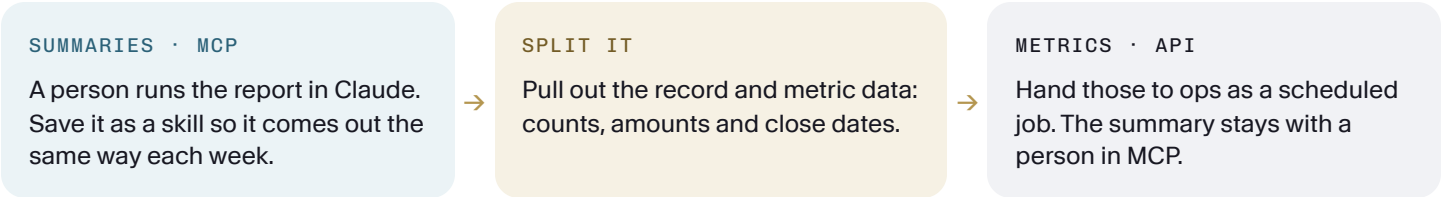
RULE OF THUMB

If a person is asking, use MCP. *If a system is asking, use the API.*

Eight common jobs, *sorted*

THE JOB	USE	WHY
A rep preps for tomorrow's call with Halden Freight	MCP	A person asks, and the follow-ups depend on the answer
A manager reviews risks and next steps on Priya Shah's deals	MCP	Every question leads somewhere new
A VP asks Backstory's assistant for 90-day themes before a QBR	MCP	Built on summaries, and the story takes judgment
Nightly bulk export of activity data to the data warehouse	API	Runs on a schedule and feeds another system
Pushing activity from another system into Backstory	API	Bulk data in, same format, no one asking
A metrics dashboard that refreshes nightly	API	Runs on a schedule. MCP can't, because a person signs in
Board metrics that must match finance exactly	API	Precision beats flexibility
Weekly pipeline risk summary a leader reviews before sending	MCP + API	Gray zone: summaries stay in MCP, metrics move to the API

WORKING THE GRAY ZONE



WHY THIS MATTERS FOR GTM

AI stops being another tab. *It becomes the layer across the stack.*

GTM stacks keep splitting: CRM, sales intelligence, email, content, enrichment, analytics. MCP gives AI one standard way into each of them, so it can understand how your system fits together and pull context from across it, not just draft messages. Backstory MCP only reads. It can't change anything in Backstory or your CRM. The chat window starts to work like the operating system for your GTM motion.

WORTH KNOWING

Access works differently. An API key sees your whole organization's data. MCP sees only what each signed-in person can see.